Women in the freedom movement


Velunachiyar

In the early anti-colonial struggle women played major roles in various capacities. Velunachiyar of Sivaganga fought violently against the British and restored her rule in Sivaganga. Begum Hazrat Mahal, Rani Lakshmi Bhai of Jhansi led an armed revolt of 1857 against the British.

In the freedom struggle thousands of women came out of their homes, boycotted foreign goods, marched in processions, defied laws, received lathi charges and Courted jails. Their participation in the struggle added a new dimension of mass character.

Impact of reform movement

- Significant advances were made in the field of emancipation of women.
- It created of national awakening among the masses.
- It created the feeling of sacrifice, service and rationalism.
- The practice of sati and infanticide were made illegal.
- It permitted widow remarriage.

Women in Independent India

Women in India now participate in all activities such as education, politics, medical, culture, service sectors, science and technology.

The constitution of India guarantees (Article 14) equal opportunity and equal pay for equal work.

The National policy for empowerment of women was passed under the National Policy on Education (1986), new programme was launched called Mahila Samakhya, its main focus was on empower of women. Reservation of 33 percent to women envisaged an improvement in the socio-political status of women.

The National Commission for women was set up January 1992. Its main functions is to review women related legislation and intervene in specific individual complaints of atrocities and denial of rights.

The following legislations have enhanced the status of women in matters of marriage adoption and inheritance.

Legislation	Provisions
Bengal regulation of XXI, 1804	Female infanticide was declared illegal
Regulation of XVII,1829	Practice of sati was declared illegal
Hindus Widow's Remarriage Act, 1856	It permitted widow remarriage
The Native Marriage Act, 1872	The Child Marriage was prohibited
The Sharda Act,1930	The age of marriage was raised for boys and girls
Devadasi abolition Act, 1947	It abolished Devadasi system

Recap

- The Position of women was not uniform in all periods and differed with regional variations.
- There were many social evils in Indian society
- A number of social reformers and social reform movements sought to promote the upliftment of women by giving them education
- Woman in India now participate in all activities.

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